cent of its traditional *savarna* vote—a highly successful feat of social engineering that united the Hindu electorate to a degree rarely seen before in the state.

If that phalanx had to be broken, the SP's old regimental formation was not going to suffice—bits of brick and mortar had to be shaken loose from that castle to build one's own. The BJP strategy had evolved at the subterranean level, while keeping its saffron topsoil intact—its Hindutva had been Mandalised, and its new OBC adherents 'Hinduised'. (Even Yadavs were not immune to Hindutva's charms.) It warranted that the Samajwadis change their game too to cope with this, emulating the opponent's moves. Call it social reverse-engineering. What helped Akhilesh and his core team were the cracks in the BJP's ramparts that they could exploit. The ascension of Yogi Adityanath, a Thakur, had left many OBCs displeased at the outset. They had hoped to see state president Keshav Prasad Maurya, an OBC, elevated to the CM's post. That faint sense of alienation only deepened over five years. Also, with Adityanath serving up a Hindutva that was hard and unleavened, Muslim estrangement was near-complete. Just prior to the polls, the Muslims, some 20 per cent of UP's population, apparently decided that the SP was their best bet; both Sunnis and Shias decided to back Akhilesh. Along with a good chunk of the eight per cent Yadav votes, that meant the SP began the electoral race with around 25 per cent votes in its tank. The thing to do now was to top up.



THE DOUBLE ENGINE CM Adityanath and PM Modi at a BJP election rally in Kasganj, Feb. 11

The SP had been in contact with disgruntled OBC leaders in the BJP, who felt their interests had been neglected and their space constricted. Says Udaiveer Singh, an MLC and a key SP strategist, "The BJP triumphed in 2017 by taking a large section of non-Yadavs, mainly MBCs, with them. But after their victory, they did not give them a representation at the district level. The BJP's district units are mostly *savarna*-dominated, so these MBC leaders felt discriminated against. They felt they were not natural allies of the BJP and decided to join us."

The plans were laid to win over prominent non-Yadav leaders, but the catchword was patience. The party waited to strike at the most opportune time: *after* the polls were announced. To Yogi and the BJP's embarrassment, three prominent non-Yadav OBC ministers—Swami Prasad Maurya, Dara Singh Chauhan and Dharam Singh Saini—resigned from their posts and joined the SP at that delicate stage, the last lap when a momentum could be created for the home stretch. Then the SP forged alliances with smaller OBC and EBC parties keeping in mind their regional spread. In central UP, it tied up with the Mahan Dal, which has a sizeable following of Mauryas and Shakyas. To expand its presence in Purvanchal, it allied with the Apna Dal (Kamerawadi), one of the factions that competes for the 7 per cent Kurmi Patel vote. They also tied up with two other parties with a following in the east: the influential Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP), led by Om Prakash Rajbhar, and the Janwadi Party, which commands a following among Lonia Chauhans. These two combined account for five per cent of the population. Meanwhile, in western UP, the SP tied up with the RLD, now led by former PM Charan Singh's grandson Jayant Chaudhary, who has built up a groundswell of support for himself among the Jat farmers after his father Ajit Singh's demise—the Centre's ham-handed handling of the now-repealed farm laws aiding that process.

The SP's outreach to Dalits had been practically non-existent before this election—Yadav-Dalit relations aren't the rosiest on the ground, and the baggage of a historically difficult relationship with Mayawati reflects that. To make amends, the